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The Harvest Festival

Sterling Castle, Norfolk, Autumn 1851

Scene 3 · The crestless carriage

The cloud had come over by five and stayed, low and the colour of pewter, and when the sun went down behind it there was no afterglow at all. One moment it was late afternoon. The next the footmen were going along the front of the house with tapers, and the lanterns on the carriage sweep were coming up one after another, small and yellow against the dark.

Alexander had meant to be dressed by now. He was on the front steps instead in his riding coat, which the stable boy had brushed and sent back up to him, because the first of the dinner guests were due and his mother had wanted the family at the door. His father stood on the top step in evening black, square and patient. His mother stood beside him. Catherine had come down last, in a gown of dark green that was very nearly what a duke's daughter ought to wear to dinner, and had at once sat down on the balustrade, which was not.

"The Reverend Mr. Ashby," she said, "will be first. He always is. He likes to have the fire to himself before anyone else gets to it."

"Get off the balustrade," their mother said, without looking round.

Catherine got off it.

They heard the carriage before they saw it, and it was not the Reverend Mr. Ashby's. His came up the hill road with a great deal of noise, a loose wheel-band and a cob that blew like a bellows on the last rise. This came up quietly. There was the grind of wheels on gravel, steady and unhurried, and nothing else, no blowing, no jingle of harness. Then it came into the light of

the first lantern: a closed carriage, black, drawn by a pair of black horses that came to a stand at the foot of the steps as neatly as if they had been set down there.

Above them, in the chestnuts, the rooks went up.

They went all at once, every bird in the rookery, with a noise like a sheet being torn, and for a moment the dark over the drive was full of them. Then they were gone, over the roof of the eastern range and away, and they did not come back. The trees they had left were absolutely silent.

Somebody on the steps laughed, uncertainly. It was Catherine. "Well," she said. "That was rude of them."

Alexander looked at the carriage. There was something wrong with it, and it took him a moment to see what. It had no crest. The panel on the door, where any gentleman's carriage carried his arms, was plain black lacquer, as blank as a closed eye. And there were no windows. Where the glass should have been there were panels, close-fitted, and the whole thing stood under the lantern as shut as a box.

He told himself it was a foreign fashion. He told himself a great many things in the next few minutes, and all of them were reasonable.

The horses did not move. The cart horses in the stable yard were stamping and calling to one another, unsettled by the rooks, but this pair stood in their traces with their heads level and their ears still, and did not so much as shake a bit. They were very fine. He supposed that very fine horses were trained to it.

On the box sat the coachman. He was a young man, thin and colourless, with his hat pulled level and his hands quiet on the reins, and he did not look at the house or the lanterns or the family on the steps. He did not look at anything. His eyes rested on the air between his horses' ears and held nothing of their own. He did not get down to open the door.

The door opened anyway.

The man who stepped down from it did so without haste, as if he had all the evening and had decided to spend a part of it on this. He was tall, and pale, and very finely made, with dark hair worn a little longer than was the fashion, and a black coat that was correct in every

particular and might have been cut ten years ago by the best tailor in Vienna. He looked to be somewhere in his late thirties. He stood at the foot of the steps and looked up at them, and smiled, and the smile was a good one. It was exactly the smile a gentleman gave on arriving at a house where he was not expected, warm and apologetic and sure of being forgiven. Alexander had the strange impression that he had seen it before, on someone else.

"Your Grace." The voice was low and unhurried, with an accent too faint to place. "Forgive me. I am early."

"For what, sir?" his father said.

"For everything, I find. I have never learned to be otherwise." He came up the steps. "Hessian. I hold a title from the Emperor that I am not sure your country recognises, so you need not use it. I have come to you about land."

There was a small cold breath of air as he reached the top step, as though a door had been opened somewhere behind him onto a colder room. The nearest lantern flame leaned away from it, and righted itself. Alexander felt it on the backs of his hands. The evening had turned, he thought. September evenings did.

His father did not give the stranger his hand. He did not refuse it either. He simply stood, as he stood at the judging table, and let the silence do what it would, and after a moment Hessian took a letter from inside his coat and offered that instead. It was heavy paper, folded square and sealed in black wax.

"A matter of land," Hessian said. "Your Mr. Hollis will find it tedious. I find that land is never tedious. It is only waiting to be wanted."

Edward took the letter. He turned it over once in his scarred hand and looked at the seal, which carried no device that Alexander could make out from where he stood, only a smooth black disc. Then he put it into the breast of his coat, unopened.

Alexander had seen his father open letters at the breakfast table, at the judging table, once on horseback in a downpour. He had never seen him put one away unread. He felt it as a small cold drop somewhere under his ribs, and could not have said why.

"My wife," Edward said. "The Duchess."

"Duchess." Hessian bowed over her hand without quite touching it.

His mother inclined her head. That was all; she said nothing. But Alexander, who had known her face all his life, saw it close, the way a book is closed when the reader has finished deciding what she thinks of it. Whatever it was, she had decided it in the time it took him to come up the steps.

"My son," his father said. "Lord Wensum."

"Lord Wensum." The title came out precisely, every letter given its due, the way a man speaks a language he has learned very thoroughly from books. Hessian looked at him for a moment with interest, and Alexander understood that he was being looked at the way he himself looked at a house, from the oldest part outward. Then the stranger's eyes moved on.

They moved past his mother, past the lit doorway and the footman holding it, and they found Catherine at the end of the step, in her dark green, with her hair coming down on one side.

And they stayed there.

It was not rudeness. Rudeness would have been easier to bear. Hessian's face had gone entirely still, and in the stillness it was no longer a face in its late thirties, or any age at all; it was only a face, pale and fine and fixed, the way a portrait's face is fixed. His eyes in the lantern light were not quite brown. He did not seem, for that moment, to be breathing. Alexander told himself that the man was simply a man who had learned to be still, and that the lanterns made everyone look strange, and that he was cold because he had not yet dressed.

"And my daughter," his father said, a beat late. "Lady Catherine."

"Lady Catherine," Hessian said softly, and bowed.

Catherine, who questioned every stranger who came within five miles of the district and had once followed a German tinker halfway to Swaffham to ask him about the Rhine, opened her mouth to ask him something. Their mother's hand came to rest on her arm. It did not grip. It only rested there, gloved, and Catherine closed her mouth again and made her curtsey instead, and the moment went by.

Down on the drive, the Reverend Mr. Ashby's cob came blowing up the last of the hill.

"You'll dine with us, Count," his father said. The words came out of him the way they had come out of every Duke of Norwich at every harvest festival for longer than anyone had kept records, as though he had no more choice about them than about the weather. "It's the festival. No one is turned from the door tonight."

Hessian looked at him. Then he smiled again, the good smile, the borrowed one.

"You are generous, Your Grace," he said. "I accept what I am given."

A footman stepped forward to take the Count's hat. Another came to Alexander's elbow. "Your coat brushed for dinner, my lord?" the man said, and it was the "my lord" that went through Alexander. The household only called him that when there was a stranger in the house, and for the first time in his life he heard it as a warning.

"Yes," he said. "Thank you."

He went in to dress. On the stair he stopped, for no reason, and looked out through the landing window at the chestnuts on the drive. They stood black against the last of the grey, every branch of them empty. Behind him, down in the hall, he heard the stranger laugh at something the Reverend Mr. Ashby had said, a pleasant laugh, exactly as long as it ought to have been.

He was cold all the way up to his room, and it was not until he had shut the door that he noticed he had been listening, the whole way, for the rooks.

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Added Details not in Scene Packet

Every detail in this scene that its scene packet does not supply, in the order it appears. Items marked *decided* have since been approved and recorded in the planning documents. Everything else is open to change in the next draft.

The steps

- The family waits on the front steps to receive their own dinner guests.
- Alexander is still in his riding coat, brushed by the stable boy.
- Catherine wears dark green and sits on the balustrade until Amelia tells her to get off it.
- The Reverend Mr. Ashby is always first to dinner, comes in a noisy carriage with a loose wheel-band, and drives a blowing cob.

The carriage

- The rooks go up "with a noise like a sheet being torn."
- The door panel is plain black lacquer, "as blank as a closed eye." The carriage is "as shut as a box."
- The stable horses are unsettled while Hessian's pair stand dead still.
- The coachman's eyes rest "on the air between his horses' ears." He does not get down, and the door opens anyway.

Hessian

- His coat "might have been cut ten years ago by the best tailor in Vienna." His accent is too faint to place.
- His smile is one Alexander "had seen before, on someone else."
- "Forgive me. I am early." "For everything, I find."
- His title is "from the Emperor," and he says they need not use it. "I have come to you about land."
- He knows the name of Mr. Hollis, the family's man of business.
- "Land is never tedious. It is only waiting to be wanted."

- A cold breath of air comes with him, and the lantern flame leans away.
- The letter's black seal carries no device.
- He bows over Amelia's hand without touching it.
- He looks Alexander over "from the oldest part outward."

The turn

- Catherine once followed a German tinker halfway to Swaffham to ask him about the Rhine.
- Amelia's gloved hand rests on Catherine's arm.
- "No one is turned from the door tonight." "I accept what I am given."
- A footman says "my lord," and Alexander hears it as a warning for the first time.
- From the landing window the chestnuts are empty, and Hessian laughs with Mr. Ashby.